



MANY CREATION MYTHS begin with a complementary male and female pair, such as an “earth mother” and “sky father.” In Māori mythology, for example, this earth mother was Papatūānuku, and the sky father was Ranginui. A goddess who was also the land itself, Papatūānuku gave birth to every living thing. Such pairings of gods and goddesses, however, did not always put the two deities on an equal footing. In many myths, even goddesses were harassed and abused, reflecting the power human men exerted over women.

Most cultures had goddesses of birth, marriage, and love—domains shared with real women. Goddesses could also be bloodthirsty, powerful, and chaotic. From Kali, the Hindu and Buddhist goddess of destruction to Oya,

“... I am the **Soul of Nature**, who **giveth life** to the universe ...”

THE CHARGE OF THE GODDESS,
WICCAN TEXT, 1957

◀ Lady of the moon

According to Daoist mythology, Chang'e (depicted by Taiso Yoshitoshi in the 19th century) took an elixir to make her immortal, and ascended to the moon. Today, Daoists make and share moon cakes at the Mid-Autumn Moon Festival in her honor.

THROUGH THE AGES

Goddesses

In many societies, goddesses—great, terrible, benevolent, and volatile—had far more power than their human counterparts. Yet even goddesses, feared and adored by humans, were often subordinate to male deities, just as real women were to human men.